

Both plans need a server

We want to cut the monthly cost. There are two ways: keep our code and move it to one small server, or rebuild the bot in n8n with Google Sheets. n8n doesn't remove the server. It is software too, and it has to run somewhere.

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Where each part runs

OPTION A · OUR CODE	OPTION B · N8N + GOOGLE
Small server ~\$5 Telegram bot, website chat and the staff dashboard, all together	Small server running n8n ~\$5 Or n8n Cloud instead, €20–50 a month
Supabase, free plan \$0 Bookings, clients, the papers clients send	Google Sheets, Forms, Drive \$0 The Sheet is the dashboard. The form collects the booking and the papers.
The dashboard needs no separate hosting. It runs on the same server as the bot.	The Sheet replaces the dashboard, but n8n still needs its own server or a Cloud plan.

Monthly cost

SETUP	FIXED / MONTH	NOTES
Our earlier plan	\$45	Vercel Pro \$20 + Supabase Pro \$25
A · Our code on a small server	~\$5	Supabase free plan. Move to Supabase Pro (\$25) once papers pass 1 GB or we want daily backups.
B · n8n on our own server	~\$5	Google Sheets, Forms and Drive are free.
B · n8n Cloud	€20–50	€20 covers 2,500 runs a month, and every chat message is a run. €50 covers 10,000.

AI usage is the same in every setup: about \$10 a month at 100 bookings. So n8n costs the same as Option A at best, and more on n8n Cloud.

Time to get there

OPTION A

A few days

The code already runs without Vercel. The new `server.js` is written and all 254 tests pass. What is left: set up the server, point Telegram at it, add a nightly backup.

OPTION B

Weeks, from zero

The menu, the form, the Sheet, reading the papers, the booking PDF, status messages, answers to questions, Arabic and English. All rebuilt as n8n workflows and tested by hand.

What changes for clients and staff

	OUR CODE	N8N + GOOGLE
Chassis already booked	Stopped at the chassis question, before the client does any work. Checked again at submit, and the database refuses a second booking.	Found after the form is sent (Google Form), or between pages (n8n's own form). Nothing stops two rows for one chassis.
Invoice with the wrong chassis	Caught as the paper arrives. The client is told straight away.	Caught after the form is sent. Someone has to ask the client to send it again.
Two submissions at once	One booking.	Sheets has no locks, so two rows are possible.
Sending papers	Send the PDF in the chat.	Google Forms makes the client sign in with Google to upload a file. n8n's own form doesn't.
Arabic and English	One flow, both languages.	Two forms.
Checking a change	254 automated tests.	By hand.
Staff dashboard	Review queue: confirm, reject, ask the client for something, tasks, MRN requests.	The Sheet with a status column. n8n messages the client when the status changes.

A wrong chassis on an invoice or MRN is what gets a customs declaration rejected. That is why the checks run in the chat, before a booking reaches staff.

Where n8n is better

- Staff can see and edit everything in a spreadsheet they already know.
- Changing a step means moving a node, not editing code.
- New automations are quick to add: weekly reports, reminders, emails, other apps.

A MIDDLE OPTION

Keep the bot, run n8n next to it

n8n runs on the same small server as the bot. We rebuild nothing and keep every check.

- n8n copies new and changed bookings from Supabase into a Google Sheet every few minutes. Staff see everything in the Sheet.
- When staff change a booking's status in the Sheet, n8n sends the decision to the bot through the same API the dashboard uses. The bot applies its rules and tells the client.
- New automations are built in n8n.

Cost: the same server, ~\$5 a month.

Recommendation

Move our code to one small server now. It takes a few days and brings the fixed cost from \$45 to about \$5 a month. The dashboard comes with it.

If staff want the Sheet, add n8n next to the bot as described above. Consider a full n8n rebuild only if nobody on the team can look after the code.

n8n Cloud prices from n8n.io/pricing, checked 24 September 2026, billed annually. "Small server" means a small VPS (Hetzner) or a small managed service (Railway).

Supabase free plan: 500 MB of data, 1 GB of files, no daily backups, and it pauses after 7 days with no activity. Our bot's traffic keeps it active.